

Did you know?

FASCINATING FACTS

★ The world's oceans contain 97% of all the Earth's water. Of the remaining 3%, just over 2% is locked in ice, and just under 1% is freshwater (in streams, rivers, lakes, and in the ground) and water vapor.

★ The coldest sea surface temperature is in the White Sea, in the Arctic Ocean, at 28.4°F (−2°C). The warmest occurs in summer in shallow parts of the Indian Ocean's Persian Gulf, at 96.1°F (35.6°C).

★ The temperature of the oceans' deepest water is between 34–39°F (2 and 4°C).

★ The highest underwater mountain is in the Pacific Ocean, near New Zealand. At 5.4 miles (8.7 km) tall, it is nearly as high as Mount Everest, the world's highest mountain.

★ The greatest tidal range and the highest tides in the world occur in Canada's Bay of Fundy, in the Atlantic, where the difference between low and high tides can be up to 52 ft (16 m).

★ Ninety percent of all marine life occurs in the sunlit, or euphotic, zone—the surface layer of the ocean where there is enough light to support photosynthesis. Plankton (free-floating aquatic organisms) float here, providing the basis of the ocean's food chain.

★ A bucket of seawater can contain up to 10 million phytoplankton (single-celled microscopic ocean plants) and zooplankton (microscopic animals). Most phytoplankton are less than 0.01 mm wide.

★ The largest meat-eating fish is the great white shark. Some adults can grow up to 20 ft (6 m) long and weigh around 1.5 tons.

★ A great white shark can detect one part of blood from a wounded animal in 100 million parts of water.

★ Flying fish can leap up to 6 ft (2 m) out of the water to escape from such predators as sailfish and marlins.

★ Once airborne, a flying fish spreads out the fins on its chest so they act like wings and can "fly" 325 ft (100 m).



Tiny cleaner wrasse at work inside the mouth of a grouper fish

★ At birth, a baby blue whale can weigh about 3 tons. The babies guzzle 50 gallons (100 liters) of their mother's milk a day and grow at a rate of almost 11 lbs (5 kg) an hour.

★ Small fish called cleaner wrasse feed on parasites that infest much larger fish, such as a grouper, even swimming right inside the larger fish's mouth to feed. Bigger fish do not harm the wrasse; sometimes they even form lines at the wrasses' "cleaning station" to divest themselves of parasites.



Spines flattened against body

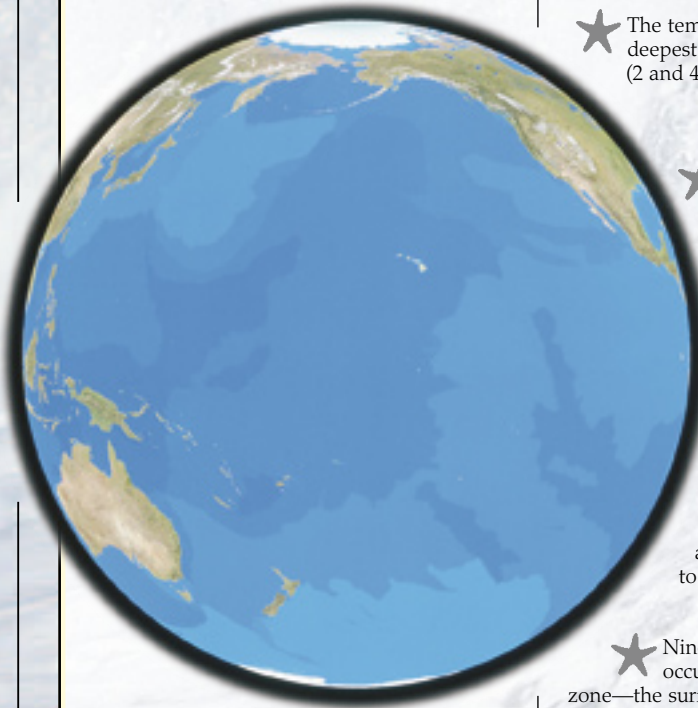
Porcupine fish at its normal size...



Body spines stick out

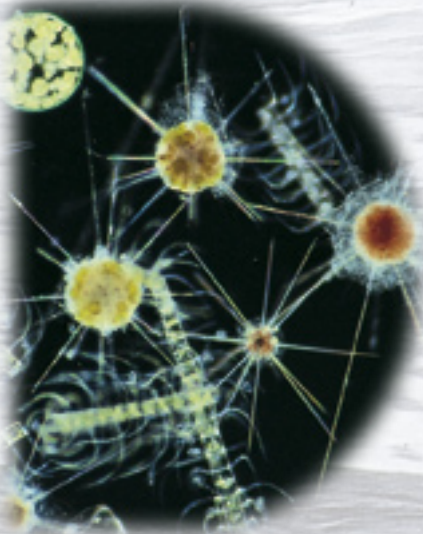
... and when inflated

★ If threatened, a porcupine fish takes in water to swell its body to twice its normal size, making it too large and uncomfortable to swallow. The fish slowly returns to its normal size when the danger has passed.



Earth seen from space

★ From above the Pacific Ocean, in space, the planet looks almost entirely blue. In fact, the Pacific Ocean, at 59 million sq miles (153 million sq km) covers about one third of the Earth's surface.



Plankton magnified several hundred times